Blues for an Alabama Sky: Key Quotations

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Below you will find definitions and analysis of the best quotations arranged by the following themes:

- Dreams and escapism
- Decline of the Harlem Renaissance
- Identity

Dreams and escapism

> **"You can't make it real just because you want it to be"**
> — Guy, Act 1, Scene 3

Meaning and context

- Guy says this to Angel as she gets an offer of work:
  - She thinks it will be an audition to be a singer, but it appears it is not
- Angel then gets annoyed by Guy's lack of faith and suggests Paris is just a dream, too:
  - There is tension here, Angel thinking Guy is a hypocrite
- Angel can be seen to lose herself in dreams when it comes to men
- She assumes it will be someone looking out for her and her best interests:
  - She did the same with Nick, even though he was with another woman
  - She is gullible and naive in romance

Analysis

- This line reflects how Guy has a realistic view of Angel's life, and she doesn't:
  - Guy is used to looking after her and does so without question
  - He is also tired by it, clearly seeing her drift into fantasy when reality doesn't suit

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

turmoil with men
    - He is trying to make her wake up to it, but she will not

- Angel struggles with the pressures of real life:
    - Here, we see her shake the disappointment and immediately lie to herself
    - She does this to protect herself

- Guy's insistence that just wanting something is not enough emphasises Harlem's decline:
- Dreams and ambition once shaped the area
- The situation no longer supports opportunity or stability
- At this point in the play, the audience may still feel that Guy is an unrealistic dreamer:
    - Angel actually embodies some realism when she questions Paris, trying to make Guy face up to reality

- For the audience, the line underscores the tragic tension at the heart of the play:
    - The characters' dreams are emotionally necessary but increasingly impossible
    - That they seem to achieve all their dreams, just to have them torn away, only increases how painful the tragedy is at the end

> **"Paris is another world away from here… We'll sleep on satin and dress in silk and drink so much fine French champagne we'll get tired of it"** — Guy, Act 2, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Guy says this while describing his dream of moving to Paris to design costumes for Josephine Baker:
    - He paints Paris as a place of luxury and glamour
    - It's a place far removed from the hardship and tension of Harlem in 1930

- Guy is happy to endure the problems they face because he thinks they will be temporary:
    - He believes they will both get away, so he isn't as concerned

- The line also comes when Guy is trying to lift Angel's spirits:
    - He thinks they will get away together

- This dream is an emotional anchor for Guy and Angel, and their friendship:
    - Paris symbolises their future together
    - This dream is perhaps why they endure what they endure

Analysis

- The contrast between "another world" and "here" emphasises what Harlem is losing:
    - There is a widening gap between what it was in the Harlem Renaissance and what it is becoming

in this image of France
    - It reflects how Guy uses his imagination to escape poverty and discrimination
    - They believe that they will go from a world of struggle and harsh treatment to glamour
    - That "satin" and "silk" are soft contrasts with the metaphorical hardship they face on a daily basis

- The sensory richness of the fabrics and drink **symbolises** Guy's desire to reinvent himself in Paris:
    - As both a designer and a gay man, Guy is looking for a place he can thrive
    - Paris represents not only opportunity professionally, but a culture he can live more freely in

- His belief that they could "get tired of it" shows the depth of his longing:
    - He imagines a life so saturated with joy that it becomes ordinary
    - This reveals how distant that happiness feels in Harlem

- It also reflects Guy's resilience:
    - He is able to sustain hope throughout everything
    - Even as his own happiness wanes, he can see a golden future

> **"I was missing that Alabama sky where the stars are so thick it's bright as day"** — Leland, Act 2, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Leland says this as he reflects on his home in Alabama:
    - Here he expresses **nostalgia** for the rural South he left
    - It presents Leland as someone who isn't necessarily happy to be in Harlem
    - This makes sense when we see how his worldview doesn't match the values of Harlem
    - Leland hasn't moved to Harlem to change, but perhaps expects Harlem to change for him

- He contrasts the openness, familiarity, and comfort of the Southern night sky with the crowded, challenging environment of Harlem
- The line occurs at a moment when Leland is adjusting to city life:
    - To him, even the sky isn't right in Harlem

- His longing for home shows that he carries a strong sense of identity tied to place, culture, and upbringing:
    - This affects how he interacts with Harlem, as a place and its community

Analysis

- The **metaphor** of stars "so thick it's bright as day" evokes a sense of abundance and clarity:
    - This **symbolises** Leland's idealised vision of his past and the security it represents

Help me understand

    - This shapes his moral rigid stance, and shows his relative lack of openness

- His **nostalgia** clashes sharply with Harlem's modern creativity:
    - Even here, it highlights the clash between tradition and progress

- The line also shows escapism through memory:
    - Leland mentally retreats to Alabama to find comfort in a world he perceives as ordered and morally certain

- This underscores how place and culture are central to identity:
    - Leland's attachment to the South fuels tension with other characters pursuing modern, liberated lives

> **"I just don't want to think about all that anymore. I'm tired of it! I'm going away. From you. From Harlem"** — Angel, Act 2, Scene 4

Meaning and context

- Angel says this to Leland as she tries to explain to him that she is going to Paris, rather than staying with him:
    - She had agreed to settle with Leland when she felt life had little else to offer, but now Paris has materialised as something that will actually happen
    - She never allowed herself to believe she could escape, but will drop anything to make it happen

- Harlem has been very hard for Angel lately, and her self-esteem is very low:
    - Finally, here, she faces that and the tension seems to explode out of her
    - Her relationship with Leland comes from sadness; Paris represents a shot at joy

- She reacts with anger and frustration as she does not want to be what Leland expects her to be:
    - The relationship with Leland has all happened quite suddenly, and Leland wants to change her entirely

Analysis

- The repeated use of "I'm" highlights Angel's focus on reclaiming control over her own life:
    - She is looking to find her agency again, having tied herself to men for a long time
    - Leland is not interested in her female agency as it stands against his traditional views

- Her phrase "I'm tired of it" conveys deep emotional fatigue:
    - She has been overwhelmed by the pressures of Harlem

- The fragmented structure ("From you. From Harlem.") captures her sense of suffocation:

- This line reflects themes of escape, identity, and the emotional cost of chasing dreams within a harsh environment:
  - While Harlem offered the chance of freedom and reinvention, failing in this environment is incredibly deflating
- The audience recognises Angel's vulnerability:
  - They understand how ambition, survival, and disappointment can collide to produce a desire to run
  - While it all seems very dramatic, a desire to break free is natural when under such pressure
  - This is arguably one of the most relatable moments for her character, who is otherwise **ostentatious** and flamboyant

Decline of the Harlem Renaissance

> **"Everywhere you've been looking lately there's nothing but a bunch of sad-eyed souls wondering who pulled the rug out"** — Guy, Act 2, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Guy says this to Angel just after Leland is kicked out of their apartment for his homophobia
- Angel thinks Guy is jealous of the love and stability it seems Leland will offer her
- Guy, on the other hand, does not understand what Angel sees in him:
  - Guy is not the type to settle, and doesn't understand why Angel is willing to be with Leland when he isn't really what she wants
- Guy is more aware of life around him, and has seen what is happening in Harlem:
  - He recognises the struggles around him
- Guy does not understand why Angel wants to settle for mere financial stability:
  - Surviving is not enough for Guy — he wants to thrive
  - Angel is more pessimistic, and sees stability as the best outcome
- He also sees that Harlem is on the downturn, and there is no happiness coming for them here:
  - Angel is caught up entirely in her own world
  - Guy knows that her struggle is universal in Harlem
- This is Guy recognising that the Harlem they love is over

Analysis

    - This reflects that emotional struggles come with the economic ones

- "Wondering who pulled the rug out" shows that people were not expecting it:
    - For them, it has felt sudden, and the Wall Street Crash did come on suddenly
    - From a place of safety and growth, things are now unpredictable and people are scared

- The loss of artistic jobs, and people like Guy realising they need to move on to fulfil their wishes, shows that the Harlem of the Renaissance is dying:
    - There would have been no need for Guy to look elsewhere in times gone by

- Guy is both an individual navigating the challenges, and a witness to communal hardship
- As we see nothing of wider Harlem, we have to trust the characters to tell us more:
    - This tells the audience more about Harlem during the Depression
    - Angel's fears are likely playing out, in different ways, across Harlem
    - There is a collective despair, and the people in Harlem need resilience if they are to pursue dreams
    - Guy has resilience; Angel less so

> **"We're not in Paris. We're in Harlem"** — Angel, Act 2, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Angel says this to Guy not long after she sees the eviction notice on their door
- She thought the debt had been paid off already by Guy, but it seems he was lying to protect her:
    - It shows that Angel, while concerned, is also stuck in her own world
    - She isn't on top of things like this; they seem to be Guy's responsibility

- She is then frustrated by Guy just pushing it aside as unimportant because Paris will save them:
    - This again reveals that Angel does not believe Paris will happen
    - Guy's continued optimism annoys Angel, who is lost in fear and worry about it

- Angel thinks she needs to wake Guy up to the danger they are facing
- Guy, on the other hand, is steadfast in his belief in his dream and his own ability:
    - This does speak to Angel's lack of confidence, and how Guy's is unwavering

Analysis

social and economic conditions

- Her statement exposes the practical difficulties of life in Harlem:
  - It emphasises themes of poverty, displacement, and the fragility of the American Dream
- It also reflects the broader social context of the Harlem Renaissance:
  - The promise of cultural liberation exists alongside systemic hardship and housing instability
  - In the Depression, the question is now whether people can continue to dream
- This grounds the pair in their immediate environment and the struggles of 1930s Harlem:
  - There is a tension to living in Harlem now, especially between aspiration and circumstance
  - This is another example of how dreams can be constrained by the pressures of everyday life
- The audience can recognise the emotional and social stakes:
  - Aspiration alone cannot protect against structural inequality, making Angel's frustration relatable and immediate

> **"Everybody knows that fire was set to run us out"** — Delia, Act 2, Scene 3

Meaning and context

- Delia says this in her apartment to Sam in reaction to the fire at the clinic:
  - She is well aware that this was no accident, and not a random attack
  - The implication is clear: this was politically motivated, an attack on the ideals that the clinic represents, not just the clinic itself
- This is a clear sign that the views we are presented with from inside the group are not necessarily reflected across the community:
  - Delia fought for the clinic because she believed there was not enough being done to help women and women's health
  - Such an attack, to burn it down, shows how strongly some feel in opposition
- She mentions famous women's health and birth control activist Margaret Sanger the line before:
  - She says people had told Margaret to forget about such a clinic in Harlem
  - "It's too dangerous", were the words used, and this highlights that
  - Sam tells her to calm down, that nobody was hurt, but it is clear that somebody could have been

bodily **autonomy**
- This is the challenge social and political change faces: the ferocity of opposing, traditional views

Analysis

- The phrase "everybody knows" suggests a collective awareness:
  - This indicates that such threats are, in a way, no surprise, because people immediately know the intention
- This is not just a disagreement, this is a specifically violent action to stop activists like Delia doing such work:
  - This sends a message
  - They want to ensure it's not just Delia who stops, but anyone else with similar beliefs
  - To "run us out" is more than just stop, it's to get them to leave, too
- This is perhaps another sign of the decline of the Harlem Renaissance:
  - At its height, people were more politically free to pursue such progressive pursuits
  - Now, with struggles more common and unhappiness rising, and with an influx of people with more traditional beliefs, opposition has come
- This gives the audience insight into the structural oppression facing Harlem residents

Identity

> **"I'm liking this family more all the time"** — Guy, Act 1, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Guy says this when Sam comes over, and brings alcohol with him
- Sam has got the bottle from the father of twins he had delivered that day:
  - The father was a bootlegger
  - This is a reminder that Harlem is under prohibition at the time
- Guy calls his friends "family":
  - Sam, Angel, Delia and Guy share a close friendship

Analysis

- This shows the affection the group share for one other:
  - They stick together as things get tough

core
    - People on the edges of society, who may have come to Harlem for its progressive scene, are more likely to be outcasts from their family
    - They had to find like-minded friends and build family-like relationships

- The repetition implied by "more all the time" emphasises the continual strengthening of these relationships
- Another sign of how they are like-minded is in the happiness of drinking alcohol:
    - The prohibition of alcohol makes this illegal, but they trust each other, so they don't need to hide their activities from one another

- This moment highlights the importance of found family and community bonds:
    - With a lot of instability in Harlem, they need people they can rely on to provide emotional stability

> **"*Spot* me? I'm not hiding!"** — Guy, Act 2, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- This comes after Guy is assaulted in the street in a homophobic attack:
    - Angel is concerned about him
    - She wishes he would be more careful
    - He is loud, in voice and in appearance, and that draws attention

- Guy is defiant:
    - He lives his life how he wants to
    - He believes he is doing nothing wrong, and will not be bullied into acting how others want

- Angel mentions that Leland knows some of these people:
    - This suggests they are traditional conservatives with hardline religious views

Analysis

- His flamboyancy is part of his identity, and Guy will not change who he is to suit others:
    - Angel is aware that this can be dangerous, but Guy would rather be true to himself than live a life pretending to be someone he isn't

- This is another sign of the decline of Harlem:
    - This was once a place where freedom of expression was cherished
    - An attack on a gay man for just appearing gay is a real shift from the individualist Harlem Renaissance

- The rhetorical question "*Spot* me?" challenges the idea of surveillance or social policing:
    - Guy isn't unaware of the danger, but refuses to be cowed

    - It could be Cleage showing us how Leland will also turn to violence against those he morally opposes

- This is the clash of new and old Harlem:
    - People like Guy were once thriving and closer to the norm
    - Now, with times getting harder, traditional views are rising to clash with progressive ideas

- Guy can be seen as a **symbol** of Harlem's courage here:
    - He embodies the aspirations of progressive Harlem and its self-determined identity

> **"I always wanted a son first so he could take care of the younger ones. I always could see myself with a son"** — Leland, Act 2, Scene 4

Meaning and context

- Just after Angel reveals she has "lost" the baby, Leland is worried Angel is leaving him because she is anxious that a second child, and son, of his died:
    - He assumes it's a son

- He doesn't understand why Angel would suddenly up and leave, and is looking for reasons
- Leland is desperate for a standard family life:
    - Here he shares his visions and dreams to Angel

Analysis

- This is Leland's traditionalist view of life:
    - He is a man, and a typical conservative man could be seen as wanting a son
    - He has shown in the play that he has little interest in women's rights or the independence of women, and this is a further hint at his sexism
    - He has views of what men should be and what women should be, and sees himself raising a righteous son

- It is also another example of how little he cares about Angel:
    - He seems to show little concern for her physical or mental wellbeing
    - He quickly moves on to what he's lost and his own worries

- When Angel goes on in frustration that she doesn't want to think about children or being a mother for now, he doesn't understand:
    - He assumes that comforting her by saying they'll have lots of babies, without question of whether she wants that, is correct
    - It's another example of his views of the roles of genders
    - He assumes that, as a woman, she will want to give him lots of kids

reflects conventional beliefs about male responsibility and family hierarchy:
    - This contrasts with Angel's desire for independence

Sources

Cleage, P. (1999), *Blues for an Alabama Sky* (Dramatists Play Service Inc.)

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